

Free of the financial worries and domestic encumbrances that have afflicted many great composers, Brahms was able to devote himself to working for his own satisfaction and at his own unruffled pace. In spite of his success, he lived modestly in a rented three-room apartment. He became notorious for his brusque, sometimes crude, behavior and sarcastic tongue, but he was also extremely generous to his family (including his stepmother after his father remarried), to friends, and to promising young musicians. Although he had detractors, who thought his work too conservative, especially compared with that of Wagner, he was generally revered, and bracketed by some with Bach and Beethoven as one of the “three Bs.”

In 1896, Clara Schumann died at the age of 76 and Brahms made an arduous 40-hour journey to attend her funeral in Bonn. On his return to Vienna, he was visibly ill and he died the following year of liver cancer, mourned by music-lovers the world over. In Hamburg, his home city, the ships in the harbor flew their flags at half mast. Brahms was buried in Vienna, near the graves of two of his heroes, Beethoven and Schubert.